

# Monument Valley

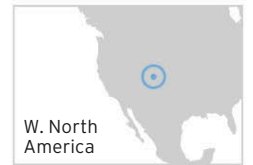
*A remote valley, where thousands of acres of wide, red plain are broken only by isolated stone monoliths, formed naturally over millennia*

Part of the Colorado Plateau, Monument Valley is a high-elevation desert, averaging about 5,600 ft (1,700 m) above sea level. It is located in one of the Southwest's driest and least-populated areas, across Utah and Arizona.

During the last 50 million years, wind and water have eroded what was once an even higher plateau, peeling away layers of shale, sandstone, and conglomerate. What remains are incredible stone formations, 400–980 ft

(120–300 m) high. Settlers in the 19th century considered the desert terrain hostile, and this, along with its harsh climate and isolated location on Navajo Nation-owned land, saved it from exploitation. Today, all of Monument Valley is owned by the Navajo Nation, which restricts visitors to a 17-mile (27-km) road tour and one hiking trail.

The valley's majestic **rock formations** began as **sand** on a seafloor **270 million years ago**



## △ RESIDENT RATTLER

The prairie rattlesnake is one of several species that inhabit the desert. It often takes over burrows abandoned by prairie dogs or burrowing owls.

## ◁ ICONIC LANDSCAPE

Monument Valley's buttes, mesas, and spires are familiar to millions via Hollywood's classic westerns. Each formation has a descriptive name, such as (from left to right) Brigham's Tomb, Castle Rock, Bear and Rabbit, and Stagecoach.



## MESAS AND BUTTES

Once part of a plateau, both mesas and buttes have flat tops and sheer sides. Their top layers are hardened rock, more resistant to erosion, but the layers beneath are made of less-resistant sedimentary rocks. Over time, these sedimentary layers are eroded by the action of wind and water, separating mesas from the parent plateau and forming canyons between them. Eventually, the larger mesas are worn down into smaller buttes.

